

Leaders From Both Parties Back a New Bike and Walking Bridge Over the Ohio River

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The Market Street Bridge stretches almost 1,800 feet across the Ohio River, linking downtown Steubenville, Ohio, with Weirton, West Virginia. But the old steel bridge closed in late 2023 after cables **anchoring** it failed. Officials say it is **beyond repair**.

"You got severe rusting under here," said Michael Paprocki, a regional transportation planner, pointing to holes in the beams.

Local leaders want a replacement for two reasons. First, the closed bridge was the only safe way for people on foot or bikes to cross, and the only bridge leading cars straight into downtown. Maura Barnes, who helps run a grocery store in downtown Steubenville, said nearby businesses saw fewer visitors after it closed.

Second, the river is a big gap in the Great American **Rail-Trail**, a plan to turn old railroad routes into bike and walking paths stretching about 3,700 miles across the country. More than half of the trail already exists, said Eric Oberg of the Rails to Trails Conservancy, the **nonprofit** behind it.

The plan has support from both political parties. Steubenville's Republican mayor, Ralph Petrella, called it "huge" for his city. Weirton's Democratic mayor, Dean Harris, worked at a steel mill for 48 years before it closed in 2024. He said trails can help attract new businesses and jobs for future generations.

A new bridge with a separate bike and walking path is planned a few blocks away. Congress has set aside \$87 million so far, but that is only part of the cost. Local leaders are asking lawmakers for more money at a time when the Trump administration has opposed **federal spending** on bike projects.

Oberg is hopeful. "It's gonna happen," he said. "The question is the timeline."

Word Treasure

beyond repair -- So badly damaged that it cannot be fixed.

anchoring -- Holding something firmly in place so it does not move.

rail-trail -- A path for walking and biking built along an old railroad route.

nonprofit -- An organization that works for a cause instead of to make money for owners.

federal spending -- Money that the national government pays out for projects and programs.

Background you need

Rail-trails are walking and biking paths built on old railroad routes that trains no longer use.

The Great American Rail-Trail is a plan to link many of these paths into one route across the United States, but large rivers create gaps that need bridges.

The Ohio River forms part of the border between Ohio and West Virginia, so bridges are vital for people who live, work and shop on both sides.

Big bridge projects often depend on money from Congress and the states, so local leaders must persuade lawmakers to fund them.

Break it down

LEAD: A closed, rusted bridge over the Ohio River leaves two towns disconnected

KEY EVENT: Leaders push for a new bridge with a bike and walking path

+ WHO: Mayors Ralph Petrella (Republican) and Dean Harris (Democrat), planners and trail advocates

+ WHERE: Steubenville, Ohio, and Weirton, West Virginia

+ WHY: Reconnect downtown and close a gap in the Great American Rail-Trail

EVIDENCE: Businesses saw fewer visitors; more than half the 3,700-mile trail exists

CHALLENGE: Only \$87 million set aside so far, and the administration opposes federal bike spending

OPEN QUESTION: When the money and the new bridge will come

Why it matters

The project shows how a single bridge can affect jobs, shops and travel for whole communities. It is also an example of leaders from both parties working together on a shared goal.

Test what you remember

1. Which two places did the Market Street Bridge connect?
 - (A) Columbus and Charleston
 - (B) Steubenville, Ohio, and Weirton, West Virginia
 - (C) Cincinnati and Louisville
 - (D) Pittsburgh and Cleveland
2. Why did the bridge close in late 2023?
 - (A) A new highway replaced it
 - (B) A flood washed it away
 - (C) It was too narrow for trucks
 - (D) Cables anchoring it failed
3. What is the Great American Rail-Trail?
 - (A) A high-speed train line
 - (B) A new interstate highway
 - (C) A plan for bike and walking paths on old railroad routes across the country
 - (D) A river cruise route
4. How much of the roughly 3,700-mile trail already exists?
 - (A) About a quarter
 - (B) None of it
 - (C) More than half
 - (D) All of it
5. What do the two mayors have in common about the bridge?
 - (A) Both support it even though they are from different parties
 - (B) Both want to repair the old bridge
 - (C) Both oppose it
 - (D) Both belong to the same party
6. How much money has Congress set aside so far?
 - (A) \$87 million
 - (B) Nothing yet
 - (C) \$3.7 billion
 - (D) \$1 million

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: C 4: C 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Mayor Ralph Petrella, Steubenville: Calls the bridge and trail project huge for his city.
2. Mayor Dean Harris, Weirton: Says trails can help attract new businesses and jobs for future generations.
3. Eric Oberg, Rails to Trails Conservancy: Believes the bridge will happen and the question is the timeline.
4. Trump administration: Has opposed federal spending on bike projects.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):